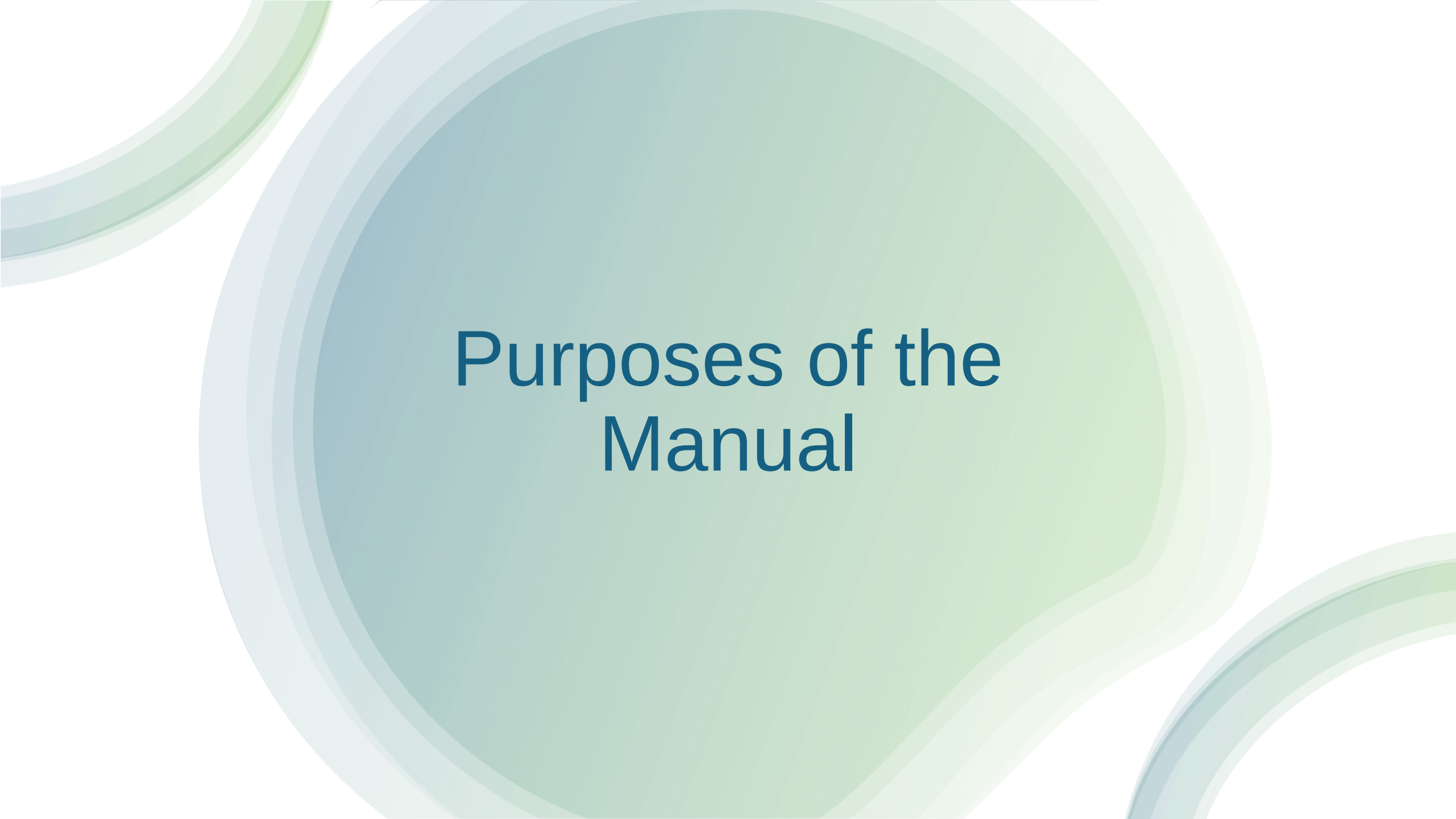


Saldaña: Chapter 1

Sam Servellon, Zohreh Tamimdari, Nathan Speer,



Purposes of the Manual

Purpose

- The functions of codes, coding, and analytic memo writing
 - Nothing hard or fast
 - Not always necessary, not always appropriate
 - You decide
 - It is all about the data

Purpose Continued

- 35 Diverse Coding Methods
 - What are the data showing
 - How are the data expressed
- Manual for use, exploration, or instruction

Purpose Continued

- Sources
 - The origins and future of coding in qualitative research
- Descriptions
 - 35 coding methods
- Applications
 - When and where
- Examples
- Resources
 - Relies heavily on external sources for support and expansion



What Is a Code?

Two Examples from the Book

“A code in qualitative inquiry is most often a word or short phrase that symbolically assigns a summative, salient, essence-capturing, and/or evocative attribute for a portion of language based or visual data” (p.4).
“Charmaz (2001) describes coding as the “critical link” between data collection and their explanation of meaning” (p.4).

¹ He cares about me. He has never told me but he does.
² He's always been there for me, even when my parents were not. He's one of the few things that I hold as a constant in my life. So it's nice. ³ I really feel comfortable around him.

¹ SENSE OF SELF-WORTH
² STABILITY
³ "COMFORTABLE"

¹ My son, Barry, went through a really tough time about, probably started the end of fifth grade and went into sixth grade. ² When he was growing up young in school he was a people-pleaser and his teachers loved him to death. ³ Two boys in particular that he chose to try to emulate, wouldn't, were not very good for him. ⁴ They were very critical of him, they put him down all the time, and he kind of just took that and really kind of internalized it, I think, for a long time. ⁵ In that time period, in the fifth grade, early sixth grade, they really just kind of shunned him all together, and so his network as he knew it was gone.

¹ MIDDLE-SCHOOL
HELL
² TEACHER'S PET
³ BAD INFLUENCES
⁴ TWEEN ANGST
⁵ THE LOST BOY

Coding for Patterns

“A pattern is repetitive, regular, or consistent occurrences of action/data that appear more than twice. At a basic level, pattern concerns the relation between unity and multiplicity.” (p. 5)

Patterns, Variations and Their Complexities

Idiosyncrasy: This concept suggests that unique or individual differences among participants or cases can still form a pattern when viewed together. While we often think of patterns as things that are similar, idiosyncrasies can share a deeper commonality.

Example 1: School Experiences

Imagine you interview students about their school experiences. Some students say they were bored and disengaged, while others were enthusiastic and motivated.

On the surface: These responses seem very different. **Deeper pattern:** What these responses have in common is that everyone has a *strong personal reaction* to their school experience. The pattern is not in the emotions themselves but in the fact that everyone has distinct, meaningful views about school.

Example 2: Opinions on Leadership

Suppose participants are asked about who should lead the country. Everyone has different answers, showing variation in opinion. **The commonality:** All participants have a strong opinion. The **pattern** is that everyone cares deeply about leadership, even though their preferences vary.

"Fuzzy" Boundaries:

Data doesn't always fit neatly into categories; categories often overlap and have blurred boundaries.

The Role of Anomalies:

Focus not only on regularities but also on anomalies and deviations, as they spark deeper inquiry and foster theory development through **abductive analysis**.

Codes vs. Themes:

- **Codes:** These are specific labels or phrases assigned to segments of data to capture their explicit meaning or content. For example, *security* can be a code.
- **Themes:** These are broader, more abstract insights or interpretations that emerge from analyzing and categorizing codes. Themes describe subtle and implicit processes, such as how *denial* might represent a false sense of security.

Themes as Outcomes:

- Themes are often noticed during coding but require further reflection and synthesis. They emerge as patterns, trends, or concepts through analytic processes, not as a direct result of initial coding.

Role in Early Analysis:

- While themes are essential for analysis, initial cycles of coding should focus on identifying specific participant processes, emotions, or values rather than jumping to themes.

Coding Lenses and Angles

-Coding Lenses:

- The researcher's theoretical framework or perspective that shapes how they interpret data.
- *Example:* A grounded theorist, urban ethnographer, or critical race theorist.

-Coding Angles:

- The particular viewpoint or context from which data is analyzed (e.g., legal, social, or ethical perspectives).

Examples of Coding the Same Statement:

Statement:

"There's just no place in this country for illegal immigrants. Round them up and send those criminals back to where they came from." (p.8)

1. Grounded Theorist (*In Vivo Coding*):
 - Code: **"no place"**
 - Focus: Using the participant's exact language to preserve the voice of the data.
2. Urban Ethnographer (*Descriptive Coding*):
 - Code: **"immigration issues"**
 - Focus: Documenting and categorizing the broader topic expressed in the data.
3. Critical Race Theorist (*Values Coding*):
 - Code: **"xenophobia"**
 - Focus: Capturing the underlying subjective perspective of fear or hostility toward immigrants.



Codifying & Categorizing

Codifying and Categorizing in Qualitative Research

Codifying:

Arranging data systematically and applying codes to classify and link them meaningfully. It involves dividing, grouping, reorganizing, and linking data to consolidate meaning and develop explanations (p.9).

From Codes to Categories: Synthesis in Qualitative and Quantitative Analysis

Synthesis: The process of combining diverse data points into a unified whole to uncover meaning (bringing together pieces of information to form a coherent understanding).

Quantitative Synthesis:

- Uses algorithms (e.g., calculating a mean) to reduce data into a single numerical value (simplifying diverse numbers into one representative figure).
- *Example:* Averaging test scores to summarize performance.

Qualitative Synthesis:

- Combines codes into categories, themes, or concepts to consolidate meaning (organizing scattered insights into a unified interpretation).
- *Goal:* Not reduction but interpretation and deeper understanding (creating broader insights rather than simplifying data).

Purpose of Synthesis:

In qualitative research, synthesis moves from scattered codes to meaningful categories or concepts (grouping smaller ideas into larger, interpretable patterns).

Provides insights that guide further analysis or theory development (helping researchers uncover new directions or build theories).

Key Takeaway: “Quantitative analysis calculates the mean. Qualitative analysis calculates meaning” (p.10).

Recoding and Recategorizing: Refining Qualitative Data

Recoding and Refinement:

- Initial coding is rarely perfect; it requires revisiting and re-evaluating the data multiple times (e.g., first, second, or even third cycles).
- This iterative process sharpens the analysis and help codes and categories become more refined, conceptual, and abstract.

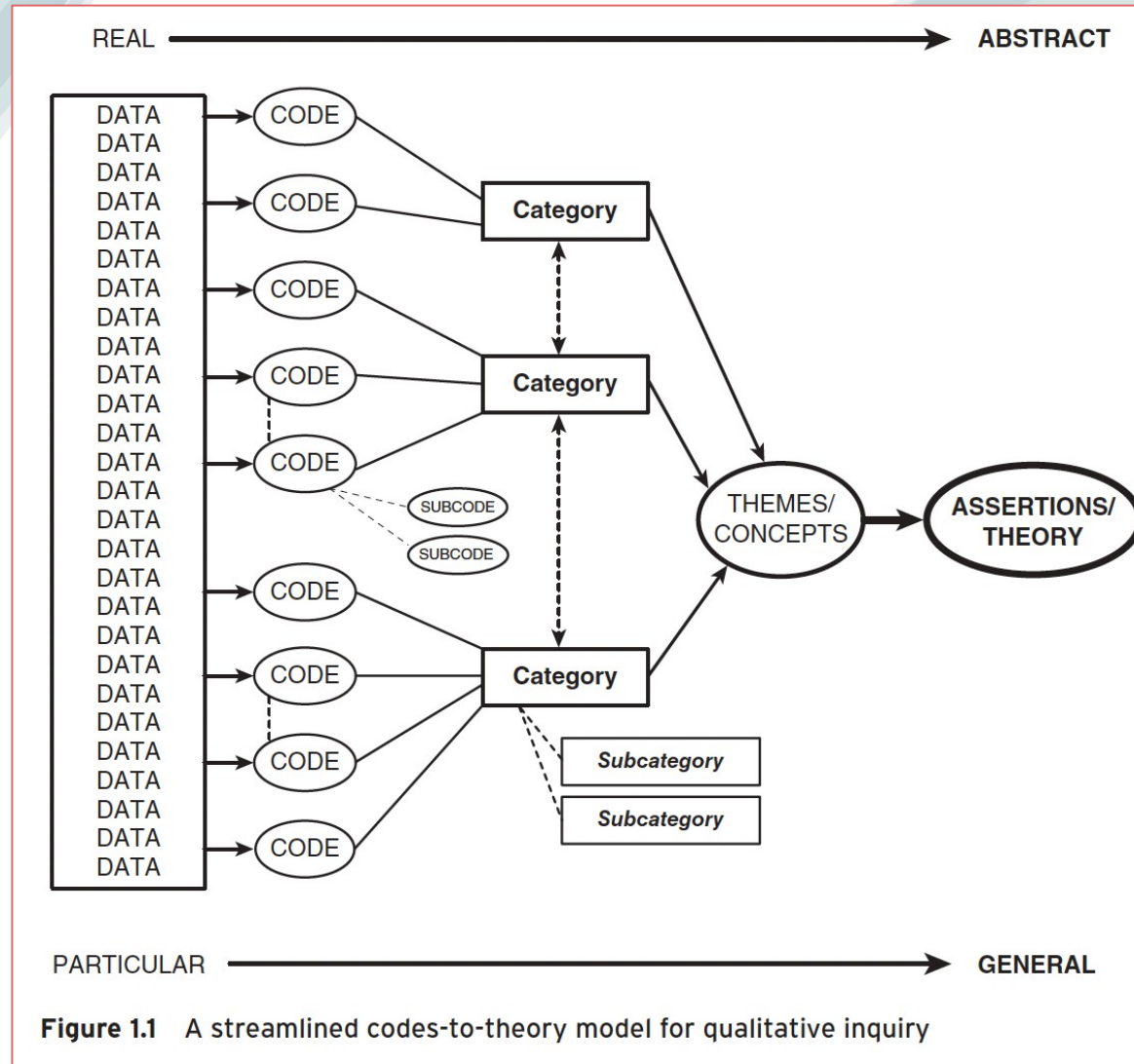
Saldaña's Example on Bullying (p.13):

- Initial categories, such as **Physical Oppression** and **Verbal Oppression**, included specific codes like PUSHING and NAME-CALLING.
- Observing overlaps (e.g., **Physical and Verbal Oppression**), new categories were created, showing how codes adapt to emerging insights.
- Over time, categories evolved to reflect gender-based differences in oppression, such as **Oppression through Physical Force** (e.g., FIGHTING) and **Oppression through Hurting Others' Feelings** (e.g., TEASING).

Abstraction in Categories:

- Subcodes represent specific, observable actions (e.g., SCRATCHING, PUSHING), while categories (e.g., Oppression) are more conceptual and abstract, capturing the broader patterns in the data.

From Codes and Categories to Theory



Coding Techniques Overview

1. Preparing Data for Coding

- Lay out data in a readable format with wide margins for coding notes.
- Divide text into shorter units (e.g., stanzas) when topics or subtopics change.

2. Pre-Coding

- Highlight or mark "**codable moments**" (significant passages or quotes) before formal coding begins.
- These moments may later serve as key evidence or inspire themes or report titles.

3. Preliminary Jottings

- Write tentative codes and analytic notes during data collection or transcription.
- Use a three-column table to track:
 - Raw data
 - Preliminary codes
 - Final codes

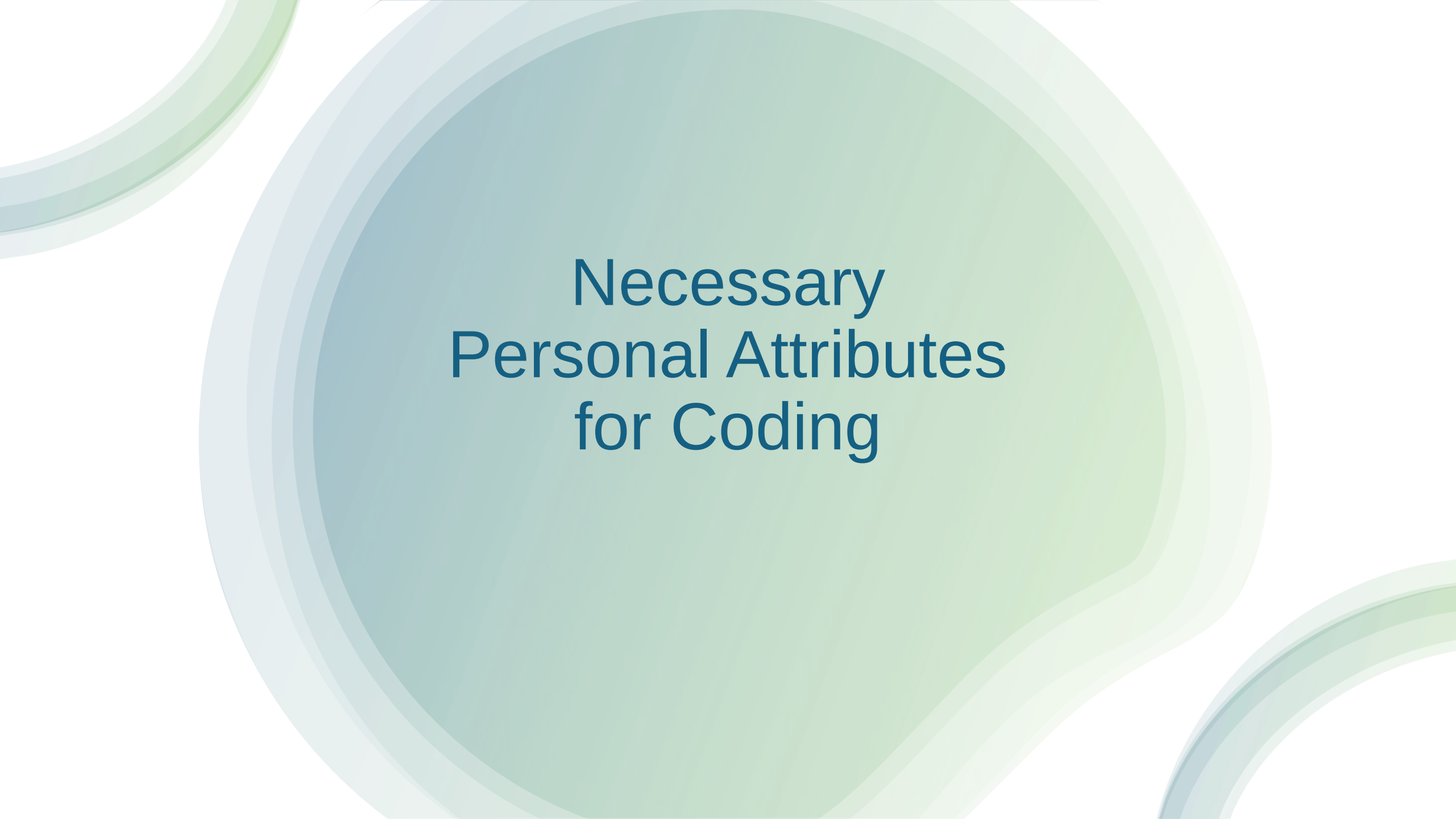
4. Questions to Guide Coding

- **Example questions:**
 - What are participants doing? How are they accomplishing it?
 - What assumptions are participants making?
 - What broader patterns or themes emerge?

5. Coding Contrasting Data

- Start with one participant's data, then compare to others.
- Contrasting datasets refine codes and highlight variability in concepts or patterns.

COLUMN 1 Raw Data	COLUMN 2 Preliminary Codes	COLUMN 3 Final Code
¹ The closer I get to retirement age, the faster I want it to happen. I'm	"retirement age"	¹ RETIREMENT ANXIETY
22  THE CODING MANUAL FOR QUALITATIVE RESEARCHERS		
not even 55 yet and I would give anything to retire now. But there's a mortgage to pay off and still a lot more to sock away in savings before I can even think of it. I keep playing the lottery, though, in hopes of winning those millions. No luck yet.	financial obligations	dreams of early retirement



Necessary Personal Attributes for Coding



1 - Organization

- A gift some have innately, and others do not
- “Organization is a set of disciplined skills that can be learned and cultivated as habits” (p. 59)
- Organization *is* analysis



2 - Perseverance

- Coding data is time-consuming and challenging
- Saldaña recommends that the researcher cultivate a personal work ethic by creating an environment and schedule that allow you to sustain extended periods of time with the analytic tasks required in coding with your full concentration



3 - Dealing with Ambiguity

- Coding and codifying are not precise sciences
- Rarely ideas crystallize out of thin air, but it is far more likely that pieces of your analytic puzzle may be missing for extended periods of time
- Saldaña suggests that the researcher help speed the process along with analytic memo writing
 - See Chapter 3 for more details on writing Analytic Memos



4 - Flexibility

- Coding is cyclical
- “Virtually no one gets it right the first time” (p. 59)
- Remember to be flexible with your approach and do not be afraid to try a modified or entirely different method altogether



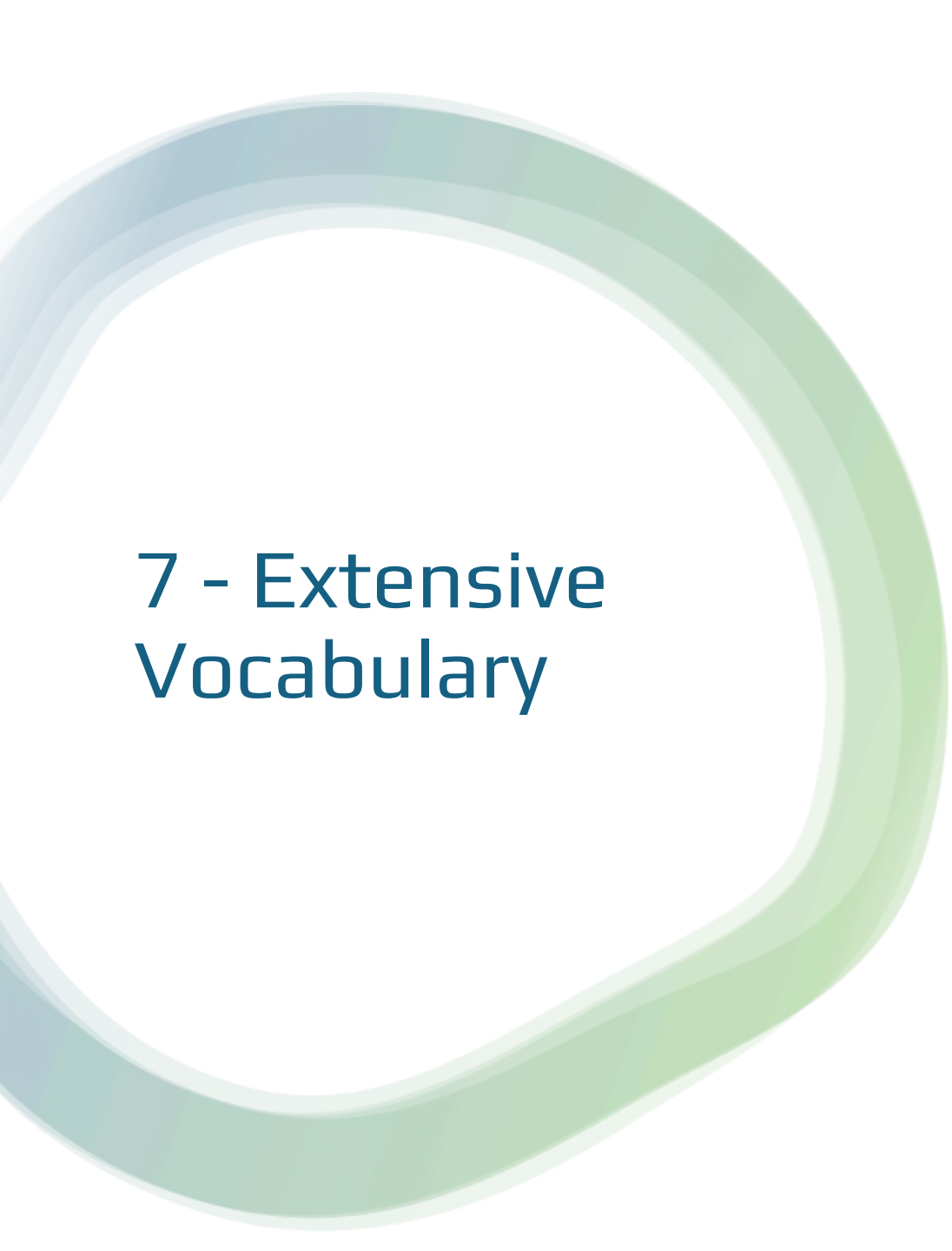
5 - Creativity

- You *need* to be creative
- There is a lot of art in the social sciences
- “Michael H. Agar (1996) asserts that the early stages of analysis depend on ‘a little bit of data and a lot of the right brain’” (p. 59)
- To think creatively also means to be able to think visually, symbolically, in metaphors, and in any other ways possible to approach a problem



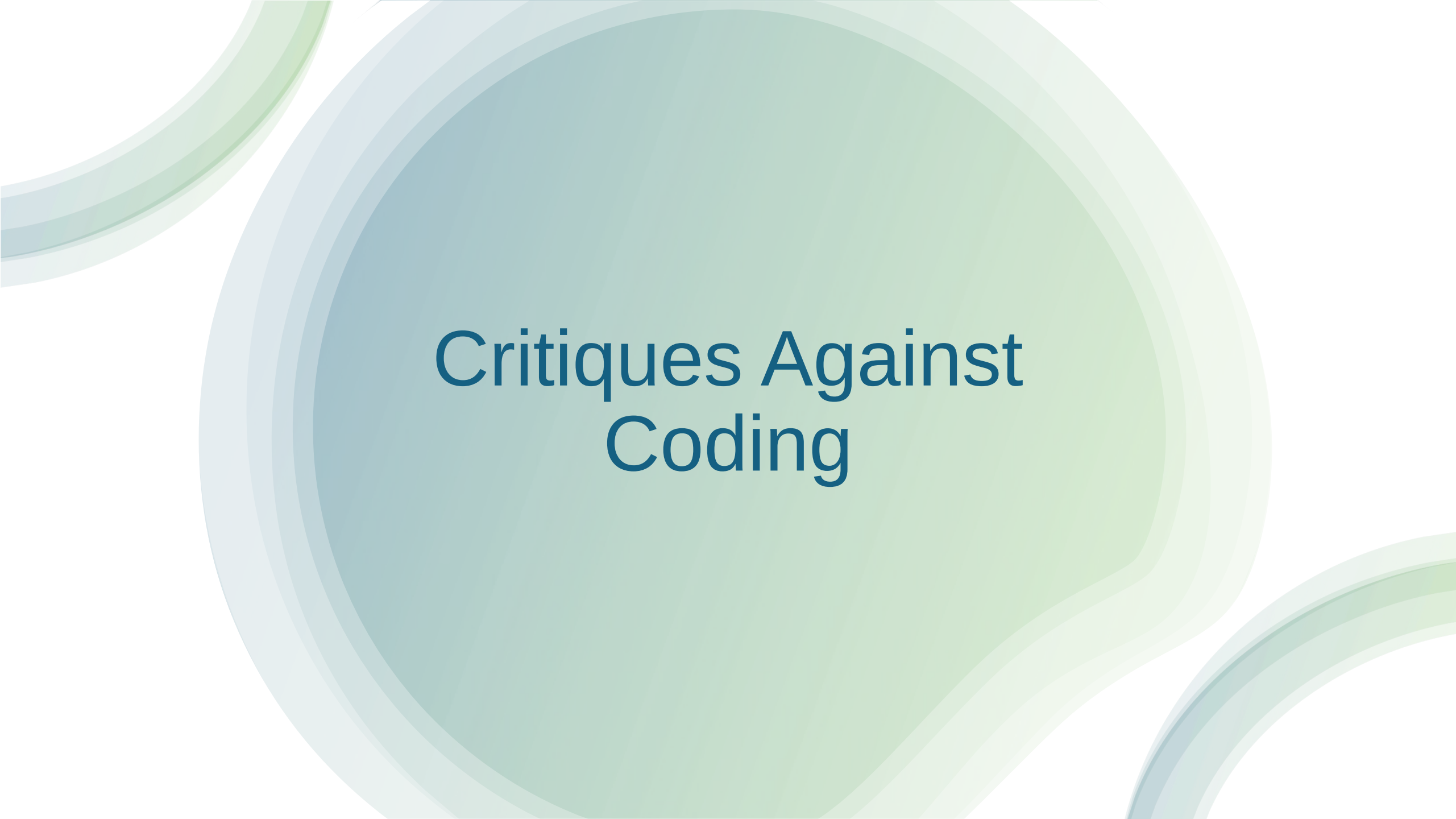
6 - Rigorous Ethics

- Rigorously ethical with:
 - Your participants and treat them with respect
 - Your data and not delete or ignore those seemingly problematic passages of text
 - With your analysis by maintaining a sense of scholarly integrity and working diligently toward final outcomes



7 - Extensive Vocabulary

- Saldaña argues that this is the most important skill you need for coding
- Our precision rests with our word choice
- Get thee an unabridged dictionary and thesaurus



Critiques Against Coding

Critiques Against Coding (What are you, a positivist?)

- Coding is reductionist
 - Coding is what coding is
 - From streamlining to “multidimensional facets about the people we study”
- Coding tries to be objective
 - Maybe?
 - “...false god”
- Coding is mechanistic, instrumentalist, and distances you from your data
 - Well...not if you do it right
 - Total immersion = distance? How?



- Coding is nothing more than counting
 - Sometimes you feel like a count
 - “counting is easy: thinking is hard work”
- Coding is “dangerous,” “violent,” and “destructive”



Critiques Cont.

Critiques Cont.

- Coding is an outdated method for qualitative data analysis
 - Enduring tradition
 - Still around for a reason
 - Rigor and validity matter
 - Clarity in Practice
- There is more to data analysis than just coding
 - Yup
 - Coding is heuristic
 - Weaving theory and perspective into data



References



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